

Some of the major earthquakes faced by India in the last two decades include the earthquakes in Uttarkashi, 1991; Latur, 1993; Jabalpur, 1997; Chamoli, 1999; Gujarat, 2001; Andaman & Nicobar Islands, 2004; and Jammu & Kashmir, 2005. In all these earthquakes, large numbers of people lost their lives or were injured, apart from causing enormous losses due to the damage and destruction of houses, public buildings, infrastructure and amenities.

The Paradigm Shift in Disaster Management in India

The high disaster risk and vulnerability of communities in India which are living in regions prone to earthquakes, floods, landslides and other natural disasters and man-made disasters invariably result in several million people getting affected by disasters in India every year. In recurring disasters like floods, we have had instances of over 2.87 crores of people affected by floods in Bihar in 1987 and 2.13 crores of people affected by floods in 2004, resulting in damage and destruction of houses, cropped areas, public assets and amenities. The Bhuj earthquake in 2001 resulted in the loss of life of over 10,000 people and caused injury to over 1.5 lakhs of people. It is estimated that on an average, more than 4,400 lives are lost and several lakhs of houses are damaged and destroyed annually due to natural disasters in India. In the 12th Finance Commission period during 2005 to 2010, an allocation of Rs. 21,333 Crores was earmarked for calamity relief and post-disaster reconstruction. However, the need to ensure that the assets, infrastructure and public amenities in disaster-prone areas are constructed to withstand the multi-hazard vulnerabilities in the specific regions as followed by most of the developed nations would help in creating assets, infrastructure and public amenities which will not get damaged even if disasters strike in such regions. In the Eleventh Five Year Plan period (2008-2012), special efforts have been made, with the help of the Planning Commission, to mainstream disaster management in development planning initiatives of the Ministries and Departments of the Government of India and State Governments.

After the Indian Ocean Tsunami of 26th December 2004, the Government of India took a path-breaking decision to review the institutional mechanisms for disaster management in India at the national, state and district levels and introduced the Disaster Management Bill which was passed by both houses of Parliament and received the assent of the President of India on 23rd December 2005. The Disaster Management Act 2005 laid the ground for the establishment of the National Disaster Management Authority (NDMA) chaired by the Hon'ble Prime Minister of India as the apex body for disaster management in India at the national level, State Disaster Management Authorities at the State level under the respective State Chief Ministers and District Disaster Management Authorities chaired by the District Collectors and co-chaired by the elected representative of the Zilla Parishads at the district level.

The National Vision for Disaster Management

The Disaster Management Act 2005 envisages a paradigm shift from the erstwhile relief-centric response to a proactive prevention, mitigation and preparedness-driven approach, so as to conserve the developmental gains and also minimize losses to lives, livelihoods and property. The National Vision for disaster management is to build a safer and disaster-resilient India by developing a holistic, proactive, multi-hazard and technology-driven strategy. This will be achieved through a culture of prevention, mitigation and preparedness to generate a prompt and efficient response at the time of disasters. The entire

